



The karma chameleon

The swami and his friends are everywhere, buying life memberships to his yoga mandir and tickets to his yoga camps

■ By Damayanti Datta

Suddenly, millions of Indians are rubbing fingernails for better hair and sucking in tummies to shed weight. All because a yogi, with flowing hair and glowing eyes, spread the good word on the telly. In the land of yoga, where gurus come dime a dozen, it's not easy to wow hearts and rekindle hopes. But Baba Ramdev has done that with great skill. And not just because he can churn his washboard-flat stomach around. In 60 years of India's Independence, Baba is the nation's best-loved icon of functional spirituality.

He can give Hamlet a run for his money when it comes to soliloquys. For the swami has been speaking non-stop—less on spiritualism and more on health, education, politics

and economics. But the silver tongue that built his yoga empire worth Rs 100-crore in just 10 years by promising magic cures (from a bald pate to AIDS), finds it just as easy to fashion persuasive "socialist" slogans when cornered (as Brinda Karat found out to her chagrin last year). "*Bargar ka matlab barbadi*" (burgers mean ruin)," says the Baba against multinational excesses. "*Maggi ka matlab kire ho jana*" (eating Maggi will turn you into insects)." Medical professionals, naturally, dispute many of his claims. But the yogi can talk his way out of nearly anything.

And he talks the common man's language. No mantra, no japa, no kundalini, no chakra. Just 'yoga made easy'. He can put India Inc to shame in targeting the right 'audience'—time-crunched Indians, looking for a quick-

BHASKAR PAUL

